Democratic Sanctions and the Selective Targeting of Authoritarian Regimes

Replication and Extension Presentation

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Why are some dictators sanctioned and others spared?

- Democratic sanctions are meant to punish authoritarian backsliding.
- Yet many authoritarian regimes violate democratic norms without being sanctioned.
- Others are sanctioned quickly after visible political shocks.
- *Example.* Belarus 2020 vs Bahrain 2011: similar authoritarian backsliding, but only Belarus faced broad Western sanctions.

Core puzzle

If sanctions are not simply a reaction to repression, what other factors are at play?

The paper's answer

A three-part framework

Trigger

- Coups
- Controversial elections

Target vulnerability

- Weaker regimes
- Less resilient targets

Sender costs

- Economic exposure
- Political alignment

Main Hypothesis

Democratic sanctions depend not only on trigger events, but also on target vulnerability and sender costs.

What exactly I replicated

Design

- Unit of analysis: authoritarian **country-years**
- Time window: 1990–2010
- Outcome: **democratic sanction onset** (binary).
- Main estimator: **clustered logit** for binary onset

Replicated outputs

- Table I
- Table II
- Table III
- Figure 2

What is a *clustered* logit model?

Like normal logit, a clustered logit models the probability of a binary outcome. The difference is that it adjusts the standard errors because repeated observations from the same country are likely correlated.

Replication result

Dramatic triggers matter most

- The replication recovers the paper's **trigger hierarchy**.
- **Coups** sharply increase sanction likelihood.
- **Controversial elections** also matter, but less strongly.
- Static democratic weakness is less important than visible political shocks.

Interpretation

Sanctions respond most strongly to events that are politically visible and difficult to ignore.

Table I: trigger coefficients

	Western	EU	US
Coup	5.127***	3.765***	4.947***
Democracy score	−0.056	−0.081	−0.116
Controversial election	2.584***	2.620***	2.275***

Table II: predicted probabilities

	Western	EU	US
Baseline	0.007	0.007	0.004
Coup	0.519	0.232	0.346
Controversial election	0.074	0.084	0.032

Replication result

Sanctions are selective, not automatic

- Sanctions are not explained by triggers alone.
- **Target vulnerability** matters: higher **inflation** is associated with higher sanction odds.
- **Sender costs** matter: politically closer regimes and regimes with higher **FDI** are less likely to be sanctioned.

Interpretation

Even when democratic violations occur, sanctions depend on both **target vulnerability** and **sender costs**.

Table III: selective-targeting coefficients

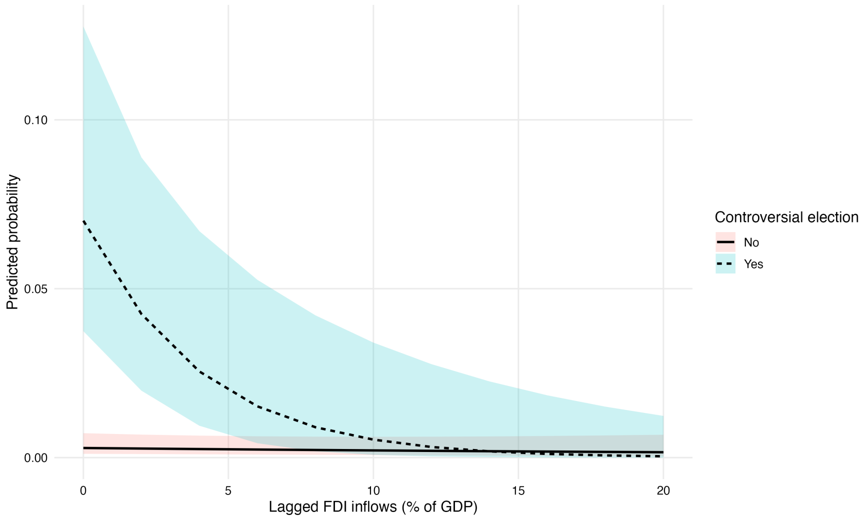
	Western
Coup	5.128***
Controversial election	2.909***
Inflation ($t-1$)	0.022**
FDI inflows ($t-1$)	-0.046*
Political closeness to West ($t-1$)	-4.413**

Replication results

When sender costs matter most

Controversial election × FDI

Table III shows that **sender costs** matter on average. Figure 2 shows *when* one sender-cost variable—**FDI**—matters most: after **controversial elections**.



My extension

Does geopolitical alignment also shield regimes?

Extension question

If economic exposure can shield regimes after weaker triggers, can **political alignment** do the same?

Motivation

- The paper already shows that political closeness matters overall.
- Figure 2 suggests discretion is greatest after controversial elections.
- The natural next step is to test whether political alignment matters *especially there*.

Setup

- Controversial Election $\times$ High Political Closeness
- High Closeness = top quartile of UN voting similarity.
- Coded as a dummy: 1 = top quartile, 0 = lower three quartiles.

Extension result

The pattern is there, but cautiously

- Descriptively, controversial elections are followed by **fewer sanctions** among highly aligned regimes.
- The interaction term is **negative**, matching the theoretical expectation.
- The direction is substantively interesting, but the evidence is not strong enough to present as decisive.

Verdict

Theory-consistent and informative, but inferentially uncertain.

Extension model: interaction coefficients

	Baseline	Interaction
Controversial election	2.817***	3.123***
High political closeness (top quartile)	$-1.295+$	-0.590
Controversial election $\times$ high political closeness		-1.784

Observed sanction rates by political closeness

Political closeness	*N*	Sanctions	Rate
Lower 3 quartiles	59	10	0.169
Top quartile	44	1	0.023

Extension robustness checks

- I varied the threshold used to define **high political closeness**.
- The interaction remained **negative** under nearby one-year threshold choices.
- With a **two-year lag** of political closeness, the interaction weakened and lost directional consistency.
- Overall, the extension is **plausible but specification-sensitive**.

Takeaway

The robustness checks support a cautious reading: the extension is theory-consistent and informative, but not decisive.

Takeaway

Strong replication, modest extension

Replication

- Core findings are successfully recovered.
- Coups and controversial elections matter.
- Sender costs & target vulnerability are central.

Extension

- Political alignment may also shield regimes.
- Most plausibly after weaker triggers.
- Evidence is suggestive, not definitive.

Final message

Democratic sanctions are **selective**: they reflect not only authoritarian violations, but also target vulnerability and the strategic costs faced by sanctioning states.